The INB/ELIXIR-ES Node Service Delivery Plan selection process

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Selection process for portfolio renovation

Within ELIXIR, the **Spanish National Bioinformatics Institute (INB)**, the **Spanish Node of ELIXIR**, is responsible for the resources portfolio offered by Spain, ensuring its alignment with ELIXIR's strategic priorities.

INB/ELIXIR-ES periodically updates its Service Delivery Plan through a structured selection process, which identifies well-established and funded tools, web services, platforms, workflows and databases. Selected resources receive the ELIXIR label, which provides international recognition, demonstrating that the resource is valuable to the user community and meets specific quality, reliability, and sustainability standards.

A public call invites Expressions of Interest in joining the INB/ELIXIR-ES resources portfolio, which are then evaluated by the External Scientific Advisory Board (SAB). The renewal process also includes a rebuttal phase, ensuring fairness by allowing applicants to clarify and refine their submissions.

By defining a transparent and structured selection process, INB/ELIXIR-ES strengthens Spain's contribution to the broad European Life Sciences Community and enhances the accessibility and reliability of life science resources.

1 Definition of Selection Criteria

- ★ **Alignment with ELIXIR Goals:** contribution to ELIXIR Platforms, Communities, and/or Focus Groups.
- ★ **Uptake of Open Science Principles:** adoption of community-driven open standards for research data and software.
- ★ **Technical Excellence and Scientific Impact:** high technical quality and contributions to the scientific community.
- ★ **Sustainability:** Ensure long-term viability supported by stable funding.
- ★ **Community Uptake:** Evidence of use and recognition by the broader scientific community.
- ★ **Gender Balance:** Active prioritization of women-led resources as part of a commitment to equity and inclusion.

2 Appointment of Scientific Advisory Board (SAB)

- ★ An independent **Scientific Advisory Board (SAB)** oversees the evaluation process.
- ★ The SAB is composed of experts with substantial experience in bioinformatics and strong familiarity with the ELIXIR environment.
- ★ Depending on the Node's strategic priorities at a given time, additional expertise (e.g., from industry or from a specific discipline) may be required.
- ★ A list of potential substitutes is maintained to ensure continuity in case an SAB member is unavailable.
- ★ **Gender balance** is also taken into account when configuring the SAB.

3 Open call for Expressions of Interest

- ★ The open call is publicly announced on the INB/ELIXIR-ES website and invites Expressions of Interest to join the national resource portfolio.
- ★ The submission process is open to any group in Spain and to resources developed in Spain. Resources included in the previous portfolio must also apply to renew their membership.
- ★ The announcement is disseminated through a comprehensive strategy using multiple channels to reach the entire community, such as:
  - mailing lists
  - social media platforms: X and LinkedIn
- ★ In the most recent review of the SDP in 2023, a total of **69 Expressions of Interest** were received

4 SAB evaluation process

- ★ Each proposal must be reviewed against the defined selection criteria by at least two SAB members, according to their expertise and possible conflicts of interest.
- ★ Each SAB member provides their feedback on the evaluated service using an evaluation form, which includes the following sections: Alignment with Open Science principles, Alignment with ELIXIR, Comments, and Evaluation Status.
- ★ A prioritized **list of recommended resources is produced by SAB** based on the agreed Evaluation Status.
- ★ In the last SDP review, conducted in 2023, the evaluation status at this stage was as follows:

23	22	22	2
Infrastructure ready	Further discussion	Not ready but suitable	Not Suitable

5 Analysis of the SAB review & discussion of the results

- ★ Applications classified with the status of **Infrastructure Ready**, **Not Ready but Suitable**, or **Not Suitable** proceed directly to the **final communication stage**.
- ★ Applicants with **Further discussion** status go through the **rebuttal process**.

6 Rebuttal process

- ★ Applicants are contacted to clarify outstanding issues and address any concerns raised by the SAB:
  - ✔ **Provide information**, such as licenses, community engagement plan.
  - ✔ **Request modifications,** such as updates to community approved registries, website content or licensing type.
- ★ A clear deadline is provided for submitting the requested responses.
- ★ Once responses are received, SAB re-evaluates the status for the applications and proposes a final result of its evaluation status.

7 Final approval by funder

- ★ Finally, the selected resources undergo a final acceptance confirmation process carried out by the funding agency, the Institute of Health Carlos III (ISCIII).

Final selection of INB/ELIXIR-ES portfolio

- ★ Once approved, the selected resources are officially notified of their inclusion in the INB/ELIXIR-ES portfolio.
- ★ Resources that are not selected are also formally notified of the outcome.

40 services

16 tools	9 web-services
6 databases	4 platforms
3 workflows	2 data collection

Explore the INB/ELIXIR-ES portfolio

Contact

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